f Greener Pastures

NOVEL, *FIRE BIRD*, HAS WON THE 2023 JCB PRIZE FOR LITERATURE



tion with his Dalit labourer/ man Friday, Kuppan, shows the complicated nature of caste politics in the state.

A recurring theme is the multifaceted relationship between people and their land. Talking about the experience of translating *Fire Bird*, Janani Kannan says, "Muthu's born a farmer...He knows nothing else. Peruma is that force from the outside that makes him rethink the permanence, introduces that aspect of doubt in his mind."

Peruma's struggles are also a window into the patriarchal psyche's workings within an agrarian set-up. Her brother-in-law, who's elder than her husband, gropes her breasts shortly after the marriage. The same brother also cheats Muthu out of his rightful share of the land. The twin entitlements are significant because in his eyes, both these things are exactly the same—his younger brother's property—therefore, he, as the elder brother, can do as he pleases.

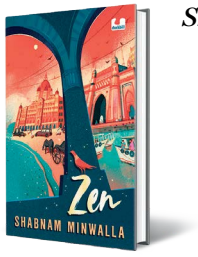
After the novel's central migration, the language of the people around Muthu and Peruma shifts slightly. This dialect or register shift is one of the challenges before a translator. Kannan says, "Where Muthu and Peruma live originally, everybody has this forced politeness in the language, you know, there's that—*inga* tone, *vanga* (please) and so on. But where they move to, everybody is curt and business-like. It can be difficult to clearly demarcate these things, but it's also one of the things that makes the translator's job worthwhile."

If you haven't read Murugan yet, *Fire Bird* is an excellent starting point, a superbly crafted story with engaging characters and a unique point of view on some very thorny issues indeed. ■

Aditya Mani Jha

ZENS AND SENSIBILITY

Shabnam Minwalla's new novel straddles two different eras in an engrossing tale of romance, rebellion and long-hidden secrets



ZEN
by Shabnam Minwalla
PENGUIN
₹499; 608 pages

Zen, the latest work of fiction by Shabnam Minwalla, is named for its main protagonist, a young girl living in modern-day Mumbai. Minwalla, who has written several titles in the young adult genre, is pitch perfect while portraying the issues characteristic of this demographic. But *Zen* may appeal to a larger age bracket given its broader sweep across history. It connects the very different worlds of Bombay and Mumbai, Zainab Essaji and Zainab (Zen) Currimji, all inextricably linked, even as it traces a trajectory between the past and the present.

The affluent Dawoodi Bohras make up a sizeable population of South Mumbai, and yet not enough contemporary writing reflects their unique culture. Through *Zen*, you get a glimpse into the life of a 1930s Bohri family and present-day Mumbai from two women's perspectives.

Expect a narrative you can sink your teeth into, sweetened with family bonds, seasoned with sibling rivalry, tentative first romance and a hint of horror, garnished with an awareness of the outside world and ways of engaging with it. Both Zainabs are strong in their own way, finding meaning in what they do even as they struggle to fit into their surroundings.

Several well-etched characters make an appearance, there's humour, realistic relationships, and plenty of political points too. There's a mystery as well that you unravel, but one thread at a time. Minwalla uses the Bohri penchant for colour in an interesting plot device that keeps you riveted.

Minwalla uses the Bohri penchant for colour in an interesting plot device that keeps you riveted till the end

Minwalla's writing reminds one of the likes of Chinese-American author Amy Tan or Turkish Orhan Pamuk, whose books create a complex tapestry that give a glimpse into the country's culture via a seemingly humdrum everydayness.

The only quibble I have with *Zen* is with the typography of the sections that are meant to be pages from the diary of Zainab Essaji in 1935. The small font and italics make it difficult to read, especially as it is not one or two paras, but several pages. It's worth the effort though, as that part of the story is what makes *Zen* fascinating, especially since Minwalla has based it on an actual family diary and years of research on the 1930s pre-independence Bombay in all its glory. ■

Priya Pathiyan